WAVERLEY GATEWAY GUIDE

Connecting International Capital with Emerging & Frontier Markets

MALI

Africa

Information current as of October 2026

Dialogue | Trust | Partnership

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WHERE AND HOW TO ENTER

KEY INVESTMENT LOCATIONS

Location / Region	Strategic Importance	Priority Sectors
Bamako	Capital and commercial centre; seat of government, the BCEAO national agency and API-Mali, and site of a state-backed gold refinery under construction since June 2025	Financial services, trade, construction, gold refining
Kayes region (west)	Heart of the gold belt, home to the Loulo-Gounkoto complex, which returned to production in December 2025 and targets up to 362,500 ounces in 2026	Gold mining, mining services, logistics
Southern lithium belt (Goulamina and Bougouni)	Two operating spodumene mines since late 2024 and 2025 make Mali an emerging lithium exporter; Bougouni produced about 27,000 tonnes of concentrate in Q1 2026	Lithium mining, processing, power and transport
Sikasso region (south)	Most productive agricultural zone and a mining region on the main southern trade route to Côte d'Ivoire	Cotton, agro-processing, gold, trade
Ségou and the Office du Niger	Large irrigated farming area along the Niger River, central to national food security	Rice, irrigated agriculture, agri-inputs
Abidjan–Bamako corridor	Principal southern supply route for fuel and goods, now operating with military-escorted convoys	Logistics, fuel storage, trucking
Dakar–Bamako corridor (via Kayes)	Western access route to the Atlantic, serving the gold belt and offering route diversification	Transport, logistics, cross-border trade

INVESTOR ENTRY ROUTES

- Agence pour la Promotion des Investissements au Mali (API-Mali), the national investment promotion agency and first point of contact for registration, incentives and investor facilitation
- Investment Code incentive regimes, administered through API-Mali, for qualifying projects in priority sectors
- 2023 Mining Code, which increases state participation and now governs major gold and lithium operations; the Loulo-Gounkoto licence was renewed for 10 years under it in February 2026

- Partnership with the state on mining assets, including state-held gold mines such as Morila and Yatéla and a state company created in February 2026 to manage mining holdings
- West African Economic and Monetary Union (WAEMU) membership: the CFA franc is pegged to the euro and managed by the BCEAO, with transfers made through authorised banks under WAEMU foreign-exchange rules
- OHADA uniform business law, giving a common regional framework for company, security and commercial-arbitration matters

MARKET-ENTRY OBSERVATION

Mali enters late 2026 with a macroeconomic recovery under way and solid policy credentials. Real GDP grew 9.3% year-on-year in Q1 2026, up from 2.7% a year earlier, as gold output rebounded. The IMF projects 5.5% growth for 2026, after 4.9% in 2025, with inflation at 2.2%, a fiscal deficit of 2.4% of GDP and public debt falling to about 41% of GDP, rated a moderate risk of debt distress. Mali met all targets and structural benchmarks under its IMF Staff-Monitored Program, completed in March 2026. Foreign direct investment was $844 million in 2025. The November 2025 settlement with Barrick, which included a CFAF 244 billion payment to the state and the return of Loulo-Gounkoto to production, and the arrival of lithium exports from Goulamina and Bougouni have broadened the export base. The government is targeting average growth of 6.5% over 2027–2029.

Mali's main structural challenge is security. Since September 2025, the al-Qaeda-linked JNIM has attacked fuel convoys to the capital. On 25 April 2026, coordinated attacks by JNIM and the separatist FLA killed the defence minister and led to the loss of Kidal in the north. The response has been practical: military-escorted convoys delivered more than 900 tankers to Bamako on 30 August 2026, and fuel supply and electricity in the capital had largely normalised by early September, although supply in parts of the centre remains irregular. Industrial gold output fell 22.9% to 42.2 tonnes in 2025 during the Barrick dispute, but is now recovering. Investors who site operations in the south and west, plan logistics and security carefully and partner closely with the state can benefit from Mali's large gold and lithium resources at a time of strong prices for both.

INVESTOR RISK & MARKET ACCESS

KEY ENTRY BARRIERS

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
Insurgency and road security	JNIM and FLA attacks, including the April 2026 offensive and fuel blockade, have disrupted transport, and the US and UK urged their citizens to leave in late 2025	Base operations in Bamako and the established southern and western mining zones; professional security, escorted logistics and fuel buffers are essential and create service opportunities
Resource-sector policy and state participation	The 2023 Mining Code raised the state's share, and the Barrick dispute shut Mali's largest mine for most of 2025 before a November 2025 settlement	Negotiate under the 2023 code from the outset with clear approvals, arbitration provisions and political-risk insurance; the settlement shows a negotiated route to resolution
Political transition and governance	Military-led government since 2021; a 2025 law gave the transition president a renewable five-year mandate, and political parties were dissolved in May 2025	Engage formally through ministries and API-Mali, apply strong anti-corruption and human-rights due diligence, and document all approvals
Sanctions and counterparty compliance	There are no broad sanctions on Mali, but the EU maintains a targeted listing regime (renewed in December 2025) and Russian security contractors operating there are sanctioned by the US, UK and EU	Screen all counterparties and security providers with sanctions counsel; US delisting of three officials in February 2026 signals improving Western engagement
Landlocked logistics and energy supply	Imports depend on corridors from Côte d'Ivoire and Senegal, and fuel shortages have caused power cuts outside the capital	Use dual corridors, on-site storage and self-generation; demand for power and logistics investment is high
Regional realignment	Mali has joined Burkina Faso and Niger in the Alliance of Sahel States (AES), which applies a 0.5% import levy, while staying in WAEMU and the CFA franc zone	WAEMU membership keeps monetary stability and euro-pegged currency convertibility; structure trade flows with customs advice

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
Commodity concentration	Gold dominates exports and revenue, so mine disruptions quickly affect growth, as in 2025	Lithium exports, agriculture and a domestic gold refinery are diversifying the base; IMF advice on prudent windfall management supports fiscal stability

INVESTOR RISK NOTE

Mali's risk profile combines sound macroeconomic management with a challenging security and political environment. On the positive side, inflation is low, the deficit is within the WAEMU 3% ceiling, public debt is falling and rated a moderate risk of distress, and every IMF Staff-Monitored Program target was met. Investors should, however, note plainly that the April 2026 insurgent offensive, the loss of Kidal and the JNIM fuel blockade show that security in much of the country is contested. the US and UK have urged their citizens to leave, and the military-led transition has no fixed end date. Investment is not restricted by broad sanctions, but EU targeted listings and the sanctioned status of Russian security contractors require rigorous counterparty screening with sanctions counsel. The 2023 Mining Code and the Barrick dispute show that the state expects a larger share of resource value, so agreements should include clear approvals, arbitration and political-risk cover. Against this, the resolution of the Barrick dispute, recovering gold output, new lithium production and improving US engagement point to real opportunities for well-advised, security-conscious investors.

MARKET ACCESS

Mali is a member of the West African Economic and Monetary Union (WAEMU), sharing the euro-pegged CFA franc and the BCEAO with seven other states, and of the OHADA business-law area. It left ECOWAS in January 2025 and joined Burkina Faso and Niger in the Alliance of Sahel States (AES) confederation, which applies a common 0.5% import levy. Mali is a WTO member. Gold is the dominant export, and lithium concentrate has been shipped to China since 2025. As a landlocked country, Mali trades mainly through the Abidjan–Bamako and Dakar–Bamako corridors, with fuel imports now protected by military escorts. Together, WAEMU monetary integration, OHADA law and two coastal corridors give Mali workable access to regional and global markets.

WHO SHOULD THE INVESTOR MEET?

INSTITUTIONAL LANDSCAPE

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Presidency of the Transition (General Assimi Goïta)	Sets national policy on security, mining sovereignty and partnerships, and approves major resource agreements	Primary reference point for strategic direction and high-level approvals
API-Mali (Agence pour la Promotion des Investissements au Mali)	National investment promotion agency; handles registration, incentives and investor facilitation	Standard first point of contact for market entry
Ministry of Mines	Issues and renews mining titles and applies the 2023 Mining Code	Essential counterpart for any gold or lithium investment
State mining holding company (created February 2026)	Manages the state's stakes in mines, including assets taken back under state control	Partner for joint ventures and the revival of state-held mines
Ministry of Economy and Finance	Leads budget, tax and IMF programme policy and the 2027–2029 economic plan	Relevant for fiscal terms, tax incentives and public-investment opportunities
BCEAO (Central Bank of West African States)	Regional central bank managing the CFA franc; policy rate 3.00% (September 2026)	Relevant for currency, transfers and banking-sector matters
Alliance of Sahel States (AES) Confederation	Regional framework with Burkina Faso and Niger shaping trade, security and joint projects	Relevant for cross-border logistics and Sahel-wide investment strategy

CURRENT INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS CHANNELS

The Chambre de Commerce et d'Industrie du Mali (CCIM) is the main domestic business body, and API-Mali publishes regular investor newsletters and organises outreach on priority sectors. The large gold and lithium operators, including Barrick, Ganfeng and Kodal Minerals, are useful sources of practical intelligence on permitting, logistics and security in the mining regions. The IMF and World Bank remain engaged, with the IMF's Staff-Monitored Program setting a path towards a future funded arrangement. Renewed US diplomatic engagement in 2026, including talks on minerals, together with Chinese, Russian, Turkish and Gulf partners, is widening the range of financing and partnership channels.

INVESTOR PROFILE BEST SUITED

Mali best suits experienced, risk-tolerant investors with strong security and compliance capabilities: mining companies and mining-services firms ready to work under the 2023 Mining Code in partnership with the state; lithium and battery-materials investors seeking long-term supply; logistics, fuel-storage and power providers addressing pressing infrastructure needs; and agribusiness investors in the cotton and irrigated-rice belts of the south and centre. Development finance institutions and investors with political-risk insurance are best placed to lead, with others entering through established operators.

FROM INTELLIGENCE TO ENGAGEMENT

STEP 1: Engage API-Mali and the Ministry of Mines on current terms
Open direct dialogue on incentives, licensing and state-participation terms under the Investment Code and the 2023 Mining Code.

STEP 2: Commission security and logistics assessments
Obtain professional, site-specific security advice and plan dual-corridor supply, fuel storage and on-site power before committing capital.

STEP 3: Complete sanctions and counterparty due diligence
Use sanctions counsel to screen partners, security providers and intermediaries against EU, UK and US listings, and keep the review current.

STEP 4: Structure agreements for durability
Secure documented ministerial approvals, international arbitration provisions and political-risk insurance, and learn from the 2025 Barrick settlement.

STEP 5: Track the gold recovery, lithium growth and partner diplomacy
Follow mine restarts, the state's mining portfolio and US and regional engagement to time entry and identify partnership openings.